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The Jewish Chronicle

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VICIOUS SPIRAL

UNTIL recently the recurring periods of tension in the Middle East, with which the world has lived so long, were nearly always due to Arab hostility towards Israel, and the question was constantly asked how long it would be before the Israelis became involved in war with their neighbours. The safety-valve which seemed to regulate that situation was blown last autumn and today the situation, though no less grave, has radically changed. The cause of tension now is the rivalry between East and West and the danger that this could produce a major conflagration on a world scale is consequently increased.

The gravity of the situation is recognised on all sides. Mr. Gromyko, the Soviet Foreign Minister, has given a warning that a local conflict in the area could spread into a world war, and Mr. Dulles, like Mr. Nehru, has stated that the situation is "dangerous and explosive." Arms are pouring into the Middle East in a vicious spiral of cause and effect which creates ever greater tension. Though it is not easy to say just how or when this situation originated, Soviet penetration into the Middle East first took tangible form with the conclusion of the arms deal between Czechoslovakia and Egypt in 1955. Although this is generally regarded as having been a direct result of the unsatisfactory state at that time of Israeli-Egyptian relations, it is interesting to find a newspaper like the FINANCIAL TIMES stating that the shift in Russian policy "was partly caused by the formation of the Baghdad Pact during 1955, which Moscow seems to have viewed with greater concern than the West realised. Egypt, seeing its leadership of the Arab world challenged, was a natural target for the new Soviet policy." Having once become involved in the area, the Soviet Government has countered each move by the West with some action of its own. When the Baghdad Pact was reinforced by the Eisenhower Doctrine, the Russians looked for a weakness in the Western armour and picked on Syria, which not only contains the most efficient Communist party in the Middle East but whose geographical position enables Russia almost to encircle Turkey, where Nato bases are firmly established. The only reply of the Western Powers to the supply of Russian arms and economic aid to Syria has been to send military equipment to Jordan and the other Arab Powers friendly to the West.

The Russians' aim in the Middle East appears to be to create the maximum embarrassment for the Western Powers and in this way to reduce what they regard as the threat which is levelled at them through the Nato treaties and the Baghdad Pact. Western aims are concerned primarily with safeguarding their vital oil and other economic interests. Basically, the question at issue is whether these aims can be reconciled, whether any compromise is possible, or whether they are bound eventually to end in armed conflict. Russian policy seems determined to gain every advantage it can short of provoking a major war. It might even be described, in Mr. Dulles's terminology, as an essay in brinkmanship. True, the Russians have declared their peaceful intentions and their desire to come to terms with their rivals. But the Western Powers, with many examples before them, maintain that the Russian declarations are insincere and not to be trusted. The result is deadlock. If, therefore, the parties themselves are unable to stop this dangerous drift and there is no neutral Power capable of mediating, it must fall to the Secretary-General of the United Nations to accept the responsibility for trying to bring this foolish arms race to a standstill. The twelfth General Assembly of the United Nations will open in New York next week and perhaps this will give Mr. Hammarskjoeld a fresh opportunity to tackle this problem before it is too late.

The position of Israel in this context becomes precarious in the extreme, as the latest messages from Jerusalem emphasise. While it may be some slight cause for satisfaction that the tension is not a direct result of conflict on Israel's frontiers, the danger of the Jewish State being crushed between the upper and nether millstones of the East-West conflict is obvious. Moreover, it cannot be overlooked that whereas the Arab States have become pawns in the game, their own oft-reiterated aim remains the destruction of Israel, and it is one of the tragic ironies of the situation that, instead of using what influence they have with their respective protégés, the Great Powers exploit the anti-Israel sentiments of all the Arab States in order to gain the support of public opinion. Israel thus finds herself denied the arms which are supplied in increasing measure to countries which constantly wish to encompass her destruction, while gaining no respite from the propaganda war. This leaves Mr. Ben-Gurion with little room for diplomatic manœuvre. The West fails to make use of Israel's potential assistance for fear of upsetting its Arab friends, and the Russians seize every opportunity to spurn her. In these circumstances it is open to question whether the Israeli Government is justified, as it is reported, in refusing categorically to allow units of the U.N. Emergency Force to be stationed on her side of the frontier with Egypt. It might be worth some considerable sacrifice of sovereignty to achieve the good will of the United Nations in this matter.

THE BUND

THE celebration this year of the 60th anniversary of the Jewish Socialist Democratic Party (Bund), is a poignant reminder that, despite the many vicissitudes it has passed through in this generation, the movement still valiantly carries on its activities. Although its membership has been reduced to a minute fraction of what it used to be, and the whole organisation is a mere shadow of its former self, it still manages to exist and make its voice heard, if no longer really listened to, in Jewish affairs. It has several publications across the Atlantic, and in Paris there is still even a Yiddish daily, which, to its credit, managed to appear also illegally under the Nazi occupation.

Founded in Vilna in 1897 (by a coincidence, the same year as the first Zionist Congress) for the primary purpose of improving the conditions of Jewish workers, whose number grew with the increased industrialisation at the end of the nineteenth century, the Bund was at first concerned only with Jewish economic problems. The unspeakable poverty of the Jewish worker and his degradation in Tsarist Russia provided ample room for a party with a Socialist content. In fact, there was a series of strikes of Jewish workers in Vilna, Minsk, Warsaw, and Lodz, which precipitated the formation of the movement. But within a decade or so of its birth, the original aims to secure better economic conditions for Jewish labourers were superseded by those aiming at securing Jewish political rights. Thus the Bund quickly placed itself in the forefront of Jewish parties crusading for equality, for Jewish national autonomy, and above all for Yiddish culture and the Yiddish language as the national tongue of the Jewish people. In this respect it did outstanding service in Poland, as well as in Russia, until it was banned by the Communist régime, a ban which still exists against the party in all Communist countries.

Like other Jewish organisations, the Bund, too, has suffered from internal rifts and splits. But one of the main causes of its decline was no doubt the fact that, despite its excellent work in fighting against the disabilities from which the Jew suffered, it rejected categorically the idea of political Zionism. The Jewish masses in Poland, Lithuania, and elsewhere, who immediately after the First World War came in their thousands to support the Bund, soon realised its shortcomings. This decline continued even at the time when, as on the eve of the Second World War, the Bund in Warsaw still managed to publish one of the best newspapers in Poland, strongly supported by a team of [illegible] writing. The party rapidly lost ground and popularity. Today a good many of the old guard themselves among the Bundists would seem to have realised the futility of their fight against Zionism. More and more of them are coming round to share in the enthusiasm for Israel's rebirth and development. Yet quite a number, especially among those who managed to emigrate and settle in the United States, continue to cling to the past—a past which, apart from the one shortcoming in the Bund's attitude to Zionism, is one worthy of praise, deserving a high place in the history of the Jewish political movements in the Diaspora.

BILINGUALISM

FULL particulars will be found on another page of the new session's classes in modern Hebrew which, under the auspices of the Education Department of the Zionist Federation, will be held in all parts of Greater London. These classes have been arranged for weekday evenings and will cater for all categories, whether beginners, intermediate, or advanced pupils. Just four months ago an "Atseret Ivrit" which was held in London launched a country-wide campaign for the furtherance of the Hebrew language. One of the topics then under discussion related to the possibility of promoting bilingualism among the Jewish population of this country. It is noteworthy that this subject of bilingualism has been debated this week at the British Association's annual meeting in Dublin. At a joint session of the education and psychology sections, various views were expressed by Irish, Welsh, and Scottish experts, who all have a special interest in this question. One speaker stressed the dangers of a "pseudo-bilingual" system that was based on emotional, political, and historical factors to the neglect of the educational, psychological, and social ones. He said that it was necessary to distinguish between a child's real native language, learned in the home, and an ancestral language. Another speaker said that there was neurological evidence for the hardening of the speech areas of the brain after a child had reached the age of ten, and it was thought that the speech areas were "senescent" after the age of 14. According to another authority, the aim must be to enable the average pupil to attain a mastery of the vernacular and a working competence in the second language, if possible by his twelfth year. These scientific opinions deserve to be considered by our Hebrew educationists. It would seem that priority in learning to speak Hebrew should be given to young children, rather than to adolescents and adults as at present generally obtains. And is it not time to abolish the present insistence on different pronunciations of the same language?

UNIVERSITY STUDENTS

AMONG the happy events introduced by Rosh Hashana there will be, for our Jewish students, the beginning of a new University year. The attention of "Freshers" and of their parents is drawn to the particulars published in this issue of the Jewish Students' Societies at the different universities and colleges. These particulars indicate that a warm welcome will be extended to Jewish "Freshers," who will everywhere be assured of a programme of social and cultural activities designed to cater for those of all shades of thought and opinion. As many of the "Freshers" will be living away from home for the first time, it must be evident enough how important it is, both for themselves and the community, that they should immediately get in touch with their representative societies and form the appropriate Jewish attachments at the beginning of their university life. Happily, they will find a congenial atmosphere in the Jewish students' societies which flourish in every university centre. These various societies owe much of their success to their common association in the Inter-University Jewish Federation. And a main characteristic of the Federation—which is indeed essential for its purpose of attracting Jewish students of varied interests and all schools of thought—is the catholicity of its outlook. It may be added that no assessment of Jewish student activities would be complete that did not mention the tremendous debt which they owe to the splendid work undertaken by the Hillel Foundation.

RELIGIOUS EDUCATION IN ISRAEL

Progressive Party's Record

To the Editor of THE JEWISH CHRONICLE

SIR,—Your readers are indebted to you for publishing Dr. Zvi Kurzweil's most revealing and helpful article on the important subject of religious education in Israel, in which Anglo-Jewry, and in particular we Zionists, are deeply interested. He, unfortunately, confirms the fears which many of us have felt for some years that "the secular spirit of the State" of Israel is so deeply rooted that religious Jewry in Israel "has given up the hope of bringing under its influence wider circles of Israeli Jews." As to changing this sad state of affairs Mr. Kurzweil says with regret that it cannot "be brought about without the active help of Diaspora Jewry."

What kind of active help is possible? We can give all possible moral and financial support to those in Israel who are striving to bring about a change. This must not, of course, be done by creating disturbances, as the Neturei Karta do, but by orderly democratic methods, using the ballot box and implemented by Israel's supreme legislative body—the Knesset.

This being the case, we must ask to which of the Knesset parties ought we in Britain to give our moral and financial support? Dr. Kurzweil tells us that in Israel the votes of religious Jews go not only to Mizrachi but also to the General Zionists, to Cherut, and even to Mapai. They do not vote for Mapam, Achdut Avoda, or the Progressives, because these parties are considered to be anti-religious.

What is the record in this regard of the Progressive Party, which is so strongly favoured and supported by the present leaders of the British Zionist Federation? The members of the Progressive Party voted in the Knesset during the past few years against the Sabbath laws, against Jewish marriage laws, and in favour of non-interference with pig-breeding. Their leader, Dr. Rosen, although personally occupying the high position of Minister of Justice, actually refused to have a hand in drafting the laws voted by the Knesset, because it would be in conflict with his conscience as a non-religious Jew.

Yet this is the party which is constantly praised and consistently supported by official Zionism in Britain. Let us remember this when the Zionist Federation appeals to Anglo-Jewry to entrust the Jewish religious education of our children to the Zionist Federation day schools.

We must stoutly resist all their misguided efforts to create an artificial barrier between Anglo-Jewry and Israel.

F. M. LANDAU.
SAMUEL LANDMAN.

24 Dobree Avenue, N.W.10.

Innuendo Challenged

SIR,—Dr. Zvi Kurzweil's otherwise satisfactory survey of religious education in Israel contains an innuendo which should not be allowed to pass unchallenged. Particularly so since it is, I believe, deliberate. I refer to the statement: "It is a well-known fact that there are many Orthodox Jews who vote for the General Zionists, Cherut, and *even* Mapai" (my italics).

The imputation is that there is something unusual in an Orthodox Jew voting for Mapai presumably because that party is regarded as being anti-religious. This canard, which is being sedulously propagated by those who are anti-labour, is one that should be nailed once and for all. The official programme of Mapai states clearly that the party stands for "a Socialist régime founded on spiritual and political freedom." In the ten years since the State of Israel was established, Mapai, which has been the governing party from the beginning, has done much to satisfy the religious requirements of the population—particularly of new immigrants. In the moshavim, where hundreds of thousands of new immigrants from the Yemen, North Africa, Iraq, and other areas have been settled, synagogues and mikvaot have been built and religious requisites supplied. In the Histadrut a special religious affairs department has been set up. The new department has been provided with a budget of I£100,000 for the first year. Its director is Rabbi Yehuda Zvi Brandstein, the leader of the Stettiner chassidim in Israel.

It is worth noting that several of the Mapai leaders are themselves traditionally minded Jews. Mrs. Ada Maimon, sister of Rabbi Maimon, is an outstanding example. Mapai has also had a rabbi among its members of the Knesset.

In the circumstances it is hardly to be wondered at that the Israeli Labour Party is supported by many Orthodox Jews who are opposed to their religious beliefs being used as a political weapon.

H. PISNER.

4 Kennyland Court,
Hendon Way, N.W.4.

PROCEDURE IN SYNAGOGUES

The Late Chief Rabbi's Siddur

To the Editor of THE JEWISH CHRONICLE

SIR,—With reference to the correspondence in your columns about procedures in synagogue I am greatly surprised that no reference has been made to the great work of Chief Rabbi Dr. J. H. Hertz's Authorised Daily Prayer-book, Revised Edition with Commentary.

I venture to suggest that this siddur adequately fulfils all the requirements advocated by your correspondent Mr. Cyril Q. Henriques. I would like to take this opportunity to express my sincere admiration for the commendable enterprise of the Publications Department of THE JEWISH CHRONICLE in the sphere of Jewish educational religious explanatory works.

It is earnestly to be hoped that all our synagogues will take the necessary steps to make provision for a much needed supply of the late Chief Rabbi's siddur.

J. MENDEL.

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Explanations of Services

SIR,—In reply to Mr. Cyril Q. Henriques's recent letter deploring the lack of a suitable publication explaining the services and prayers of the synagogue, I am pleased to state that I have prepared a small volume entitled "A Companion to the High-Festival Machzor," which will be published in time for the forthcoming Festivals. The volume comprises historical and homiletical explanations of the services and prayers of Rosh Hashana and Yom Kippur.

(Rabbi) A. L. RUBINSTEIN.

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NO RABBIS AT THE JAMBOREE

Scouts' Self-Reliance at Services

To the Editor of THE JEWISH CHRONICLE

SIR,—I was appointed by the Council of Jewish Scouters to look after Jewish affairs at the Jamboree, and as I am a Scout Commissioner and not a rabbi, perhaps I may comment on the sting in the tail of your leading article of August 30.

The Council of Jewish Scouters records with gratitude the work of many of its chaplains, especially as most of their work goes unseen and unpublicised. We would have welcomed one or more of our chaplains at the Jamboree, but those rabbis who know scouting well thought that the scouts would themselves undertake such religious services as they wanted and that the services of a rabbi were not essential.

This was so: Israel, may we be grateful for it, is a nation of priests, not a priest-ridden nation, and scouts, as all your readers should know by now, hold "Duty to God" as the first part of their Scout Promise. It was therefore so very natural that at a Jamboree attended by the cream of scouts from all over the world, scouts of the Jewish faith could be expected, almost as part of their duty, to carry out their religious obligations without the aid of any officiating clergy.

The Jewish scout services were unique in this respect throughout the Jamboree: comments about this were more numerous than comments that the Chief Rabbi was absent. Scouts of great competence in our faith willingly came forward and with joy organised and held the services on Friday evening and on Sabbath, as well as those [illegible]

[illegible] that gush forth when officiating clergy feel they have to show they are worth their salt. In any case what language other than Hebrew would have been common to those present? I am not an Orthodox Jew, and with me was also a Reform rabbi from America deeply experienced in scouting, and while we both felt the traditional services were long and heavy going for those unfortunate scouts whose Hebrew was too scanty even for the liturgy, at the same time we, as well as others, found these services some of the most inspiring and unifying moments of the whole Jamboree. I doubt if the presence of a rabbi could have made any improvement on this.

Nevertheless, I found my task a very hard one, and the presence of a rabbi would have been welcomed for two reasons: first that his presence would have been symbolic to all the Jewish scouts from this country and overseas that the Chief Rabbi of the host country welcomed them, and secondly it would have halved my work—at least I would not have had to appear on television to explain how Judaism linked up with the Scout Law and Promise.

Scouting in the Jewish community is as old as scouting itself, but the past 50 years have not fully established the idea of scouting among the whole of our community. I think this Jamboree has been a wonderful demonstration to British Jewry of what scouting means, and I honestly believe that several thousands of British Jews have only now begun to appreciate what we are doing in this international movement of friendship and brotherhood. Perhaps in another 50 years when we hold the Centenary Jamboree we shall be able to have a [illegible] to choose which lucky boy of the [illegible] rabbis shall be permitted to [illegible].

[illegible] E. GINSBURG.

[illegible]

SPINOZA AND THE RELIGIOUS JEW OF TODAY*

By LEON ROTH

SPINOZA was born in Amsterdam on November 24, 1632, and died at The Hague on February 21, 1677. His reputation rests principally on two books, the "Tractatus Theologico-Politicus," published anonymously in 1670, and the "Ethica," published in 1677 by his friends as a part of his *Opera Posthuma*. Of these two books it was the former, the "Tractatus Theologico-Politicus," which in its time created the stir. The "Ethica" waited for notice a full hundred years.

Yet, once noticed, the "Ethica" came into its own; the "Tractatus" passed into history. The "Tractatus" belongs to time, the "Ethica" to eternity; and it is this distinction, the distinction between the things of time and the things of eternity, so strikingly exemplified in the history of Spinoza's own work, which is the main lesson that men of religion today can derive from the study of Spinoza.

Freedom Essential

The "Tractatus Theologico-Politicus" or the Treatise—as I propose to call it for short—is a reasoned plea (possibly the first, certainly one of the most striking, in modern political literature) for *complete* freedom of thought and expression (even John Locke's notable Letters on Toleration admit serious restrictions). The Treatise asserts *not* that the granting of this complete freedom by Governments is *possible* but that it is *essential*. Freedom cannot only be conceded *without harm* to the community. The community *suffers harm if deprived* of it. Freedom is the first condition of social health and well-being. It is the prerequisite of civilised living. Without it society becomes rotten, government becomes corrupt, the citizen a mindless automaton.

This lesson has been rediscovered by our generation in the course of the strains and stresses of our own day. When we read such sentences as these (*cap.* xx):

> "The ultimate aim of the State is not to tyrannise, or hold men in by fear and make them dependent, but on the contrary to free every man from fear that he may live in all possible security; that is to say, that may retain in its fullness the natural right to exist and act without harming himself and others. No, I say, the object of the State is not to change men from rational beings into beasts or puppets but, on the contrary, to help their minds and bodies to perform in safety their proper functions, and then themselves to use their reason freely and not struggle against others in hatred, anger, or deceit or be stirred against one another in enmity. In very fact, therefore, the true aim of the State is liberty."

When we read sentences such as these, we rub our eyes and ask whether they were not written yesterday. The general conclusion of the Treatise is thus startlingly fresh. What is so puzzling about it is the way it was reached. Open the Treatise, and you may think that, in its first half at least, you have before you a Biblical scholar's notebook written on the interleaving of a volume of sermons. Now it is just this seemingly irrelevant material which is of importance to our immediate subject.

For the irrelevances are not really irrelevant. One of the greatest freedoms, freedom of worship, is not unconnected with freedom of expression, and freedom of expression with freedom of belief; and belief has something to do with religion, and religion (dare I say it?) with Judaism, and a primary source, and stimulus, for the understanding both of religion and of Judaism may not unreasonably be seen in the Bible. So the Treatise, although its object is the demonstration of a principle of politics, spends much time in discussing the Bible.

Simple Moral Rules

Taking the Bible in our hands then, and accepting it, as Spinoza insists, in its own light and at its own valuation, what do we find? Well, *Spinoza* finds a lot of unexpected things. He finds, for example, that—for the Bible—belief in God does not depend on miracle (rather, belief in miracle on belief in God). He finds that—according to the Bible—prophecy was not unique to the Jews. He finds that the pre-eminence of the Jewish prophets was not intellectual but moral, and that their teaching had nothing to do with philosophical or scientific truths. He finds that religion—for the Bible—lies not in knowledge but in obedience, obedience to simple moral rules. He even finds—remember that he is writing in the seventeenth century—that (for the Bible) opinion on matters of religious belief can not only vary (and be allowed to vary) from one man to another, but also in the mind of one and the same man, without the essentials of religion being affected. All this, we read in the Treatise, is the clear doctrine of the Bible; and therefore—according to the Bible—creeds and catechisms, that is, metaphysical formulations of belief, have no place in State legislation. The State can only require its citizens to act morally. It cannot require them to think logically. It can impose upon them rules of conduct. It can impose upon them articles of belief. So far as the Bible is concerned, everybody can think what he likes and say what he thinks, provided that he acts justly and is kind to his fellow-men. That is religion, the religion of the Bible, says the Treatise. The rest is metaphysics and a man's private affair.

It is not to my purpose here to discuss the validity of these positions. Paradoxical as some of them may appear to be, I fancy that Spinoza is right; right, that is, in affirming that these are in fact the fundamental positions of the Bible. But it is obvious that the Bible voices other attitudes as well, attitudes not of tolerance but of intolerance. Spinoza is constrained therefore to inquire into the nature and source of these too.

Political Vocation

His solution is simple. Broadly speaking, he assigns all the fine things of the Bible to what he calls Universal Religion, all the unpleasant things to what he calls the Hebrew "Respublica" (that is, Commonwealth) as it is based on the Mosaic Code which is tacitly equated by him with Judaism.

We are thus brought to the consideration of Judaism, or, rather, of Spinoza's account of it.

Spinoza's account of Judaism is contained principally in his chapters on the Vocation of the Hebrews (iii), the Ceremonial Law (v), and the Hebrew Theocracy (xvii).

Briefly—and I remind you that Spinoza is reporting what he says he finds in the Bible—the "vocation" (that is, the "call") of the Hebrews was political only. Its end, he says, was the "formation of a society with fixed laws; the occupation of a strip of territory; and the concentration of all forces, as it were, into one body, that is, the body of the society." The excellence of the Hebrews lay in their political organisation alone. Their laws were indeed remarkable; but these laws, including the laws of their religion, were intended only to produce obedience to the social order and to promote its conservation. The Mosaic Code was given to and for the Hebrews alone. Its ceremonies, like the inducements it offers to obedience, were local and temporal only. They looked solely to the preservation of the Hebrew community. The religion which is Judaism is thus (according to this view) the cement which bound together the Mosaic State; and its value, a value which is derivative and adventitious, not intrinsic, lay in its use for the preservation of that State: it was an instrument to aid its survival. It was, as it were, the cocoon spun by the State out of the juices of its own body for the purpose of its own protection.

Spinoza follows the conventional (and to my mind, unfortunate and misleading) view that there are to be distinguished in it the two parts of ceremony and morality. The ceremonial consisted in certain customs and habits of behaviour; and with the political disappearance of the community in which it inhered, its reason for existence disappeared. The moral, summed up in the principles of love and kindness and justice, was also intended to strengthen the society; but owing to the intuition of the Prophets it became clear that what was salutary for this one society was salutary for all societies, and thus the ideals of love and justice, because they transcended the bounds of the Hebraic State, survived its destruction and became the foundations of the religion of mankind. This religion is non-political in the sense that it is not confined to any one nation or to any one country. It knows no monopolies, that is no chosen people and no promised land. It rejects the very idea of credal sectarianism; but since men differ in their opinions (as Spinoza remarks) as much as they do in their faces, the uniformity it requires is not of creed but of moral action.

Baruch Spinoza (1632-77)

Device for Survival

We are here (on Biblical grounds) at the general conclusion of the Treatise as a whole. So far as Spinoza's specific account of Judaism is concerned, it will be noted that in his view Judaism is universalist by accident and never so (apparently) for Jews. In essence it is, in the narrow sense, political and (in Spinoza's view) narrowly and savagely political; and those who love to quote his remark on the *possibility* of the re-emergence of the Hebraic State would do well to ponder the reasons he gives in a later passage for its *inadvisability*. Judaism for Spinoza is a tribal habit of life, isolationist and misanthropic, a device for group survival.

And we survive. But by virtue of what? On Spinoza's principles it would seem we have no right to. The cement of a political community would naturally be expected to disappear with the disappearance of that community. In *this* case, however, the political community disappeared but the cement remained, itself to create a community of a different kind altogether. But we may leave this general puzzle and ask whether, on Spinoza's own express ground, the ground of the Bible, we need accept Spinoza's theory at all.

An inquiry of this nature is the proper task of our theologians and I hesitate to intrude into their sphere. But certain points leap to the eye. For example, when Spinoza speaks of the "call" of the Jewish people, he speaks of it as a bare political fact. He says nothing of its moral end. But according to the Bible which Spinoza says he is expounding, this moral end is of the very essence of the call: without it the call is no call at all. The very first charter of Jewry—according to the Bible—makes Jewry dependent on Judaism, almost a "function" of Judaism. "For I have known him." God is represented as saying to Abraham long before the seed of Abraham grew into the people in which all the nations of the earth are to be blessed, "For I have known him *to the end that* he may command his children and his household after him, that they may keep the way of God, to do justice and judgment." For a student of the Bible this is plain enough; and I need hardly remind students of later Judaism that this verse is constantly used in this "charter" sense by the great systematiser and shaper of our own Judaism, Moses Maimonides. In the Bible itself the conception is repeated constantly, and in various forms on other—Biblically speaking—crucial occasions.

Teaching Ignored

Yet of all this I find nothing in Spinoza. Nor do I find the prophetic conception of Witness; nor the no less striking and prominent doctrine of the Remnant; nor the constant Biblical emphasis that the fulfilment of the promises is dependent on the fulfilment of the conditions, the *moral* conditions under which the promises were given; nor the constant calling of the people back to the primary decencies of moral living. Biblical Judaism is always *ahead of* the Jewish people, always *in advance of* them, always telling them in no uncertain fashion what they should be doing and what they should not be doing. "They may cry, We, Israel know thee; but Israel hath cast off what is good." "God hath a controversy with the inhabitants of the land, because there is no truth, nor mercy, nor knowledge of God in the land; there is naught but swearing and breaking faith and killing and stealing." That is the authentic voice of Judaism, yet it is not saying what on Spinoza's theory one would have expected it to say. On Spinoza's theory one would have expected the "comforting words" of the Prophets stigmatised in the Bible as *false*, what we recognise today as the propagandists bolstering up a political régime or giving "pep" to the morale of its so-called citizens. Spinoza is impressed, and rightly impressed, with the universality of the prophetic teaching. He ignores the moral obligation and the moral function which that very teaching imposed on the Jewish people. Take that away, and (as Amos said) the Jews are just such another wandering tribe as the Ethiopians and the Philistines.

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* This article is an extract from a paper read at the Tenth International Congress of the World Union for Progressive Judaism, Amsterdam, July, 1957.

AN ISRAELI LOOKS AT AMERICAN JEWRY

By BERTHA URDANG

BORN in London and educated there and in Paris, I grew up in the rosy days of Fabianism of the 'twenties, and was largely unaware of a Jewish situation, let alone a Jewish problem. In 1932 I visited Palestine and found there values about which I had been indulging in endless talk. In 1933 a drought in Palestine made me think twice about taking my daily bath in London, so, in 1934, I emigrated.

I can remember little of organised Jewish life in the London of my youth, and odd periods of months or even a year spent there in the years since I emigrated have added little to my picture, either positive or negative, but simply a blank canvas.

"Lost Generation"

I have just spent over a year in the United States of America, and several aspects of American Jewish life, negative no less than positive, made a deep impact on me. The parents born in America from the turn of the century onwards call themselves "the lost generation." They revolted in their youth, and were helped in that revolt by the depression. Everything which preceded the depression was bad, and among the bad things to be avoided was the Judaism their parents had imported with them from Europe. As parents and even as young grandparents the vast majority of this generation has been slowly growing towards a reappraisal of Jewish values and seeking somehow to reinfuse them not only into their own lives but into the lives of their growing children and even young grandchildren. The need is not yet shared by the youth itself, but the perplexity of the older people who had lost faith is very real.

My own life in England and even in Palestine and Israel never having been spent in isolation from non-Jewish friends, I was amazed and concerned at the almost total lack of relaxed, casual friendliness between Jew and non-Jew outside professional interests and after working hours. This, though, is part and parcel of the American scene in general: it is a huge pattern of parallel cultures integrating during working hours but falling apart at week-ends and after working hours. The child is an American at school, but fits back into another cultural pattern in his district and home environment, and, from this point of view, Jewish life is no exception to the general pattern. The pattern does change in academic, scientific, and art circles, and it is less rigid where small Jewish populations live in largish cities, and even less rigid still in small-town life. But here the social intercourse between Jew and non-Jew is dearly bought, for the price seems to be a slow disintegration of Jewish values and an almost complete cleavage with Jewish life.

Judæo-Christian relations are consciously fostered in parent-teacher groups, between synagogue and church groups, particularly in the Reform movement—which, by the way, is much warmer, much more Jewish than I had thought—but, in its quality, it is still "professional" cultivation of relations and lacks the spontaneity and casualness which are the hallmark of true inter-cultural friendships.

Hopeful Signs

Nowhere did I find in the youth—and I travelled extensively—anything but a *faute de mieux* acceptance of their heritage as Jews. Their knowledge was sketchy in the extreme and nothing important enough had been given them on to which they could build a real Judaism. Yet there were odd hopeful signs: one twelve-year-old boy attending Hebrew classes in a Conservative synagogue in a new and young community on Long Island, who had never seen a Seder in his own home, came to the young rabbi and asked him for the loan of skullcaps and hagadot, and said he had learned enough himself to be able to conduct a Seder. This would be the first Seder in his parents' married life.

The rôle of the rabbi in the two main trends in American Jewry—the Conservative and the Reform—is crucial and, in this respect, American Jewry is to be envied. Young, intelligent, often intellectual men, who care about the day and age in which they live, have chosen to equip themselves from within their own specific faith and culture, about which they appear to care deeply. Their rôle is not to be envied, not in the smallest degree. Theirs is an uphill task, and many are saved from completely caustic scepticism only by a fine sense of humour. But, seeking to filter through the deep crust of ignorance, materialism, and empty conformism, they do slowly make an impact, in many cases a deep impact. Theirs is a crucial rôle in the survival of American Jewry, and its full story has yet to be written.

Reform Movement

The Reform movement sees itself not as a compromise but as a result of rethinking in contemporary conditions in America. It is too soon to know exactly what can be the future of this trend, but one thing stands out at this stage: an overwhelming sincerity. It now seems to me no accident that some of the great visionaries of American Jewry with regard to early Zionism came from the Reform movement, while it is equally no accident that the main stream of Reform Judaism does not accept the importance and focal rôle in Israel in Jewish life.

It is from within the Reform movement that what I have called the "sanely conditional" acceptance of the rôle of Israel emanates. The condition is explicit, not, as in Conservative Judaism, implicit. Jewish life in America is for them an end in itself, not a means to an end. On these terms they have come to learn to feel for Israel. They will tend to emigrate to Israel less than any other Jewish trends I saw, in so far as individual immigrants from within and influenced by groups are concerned. They do not believe that the Diaspora is doomed. They do not suffer from a feeling of guilt, warm as they, as individuals, may feel towards Israel. On this issue there is no compromise, and the realisation of the rôle of Israel is, within their ranks, never focal, at best peripheral.

Not Impressive

Before discussing the Conservative and the Reconstructionist movement within it, I must apologise for the fact that my many contacts with the main stream of Orthodox Judaism in America did not impress me. No attempt had been made to face the contemporary situation. It seemed to me that Orthodox Judaism—leaving out the fundamentalism of the extremists—was content to be self-perpetuating.

The main Reconstructionist synagogue in Manhattan is a hive of cultural activity of a kind unparalleled anywhere else in the United States, unless I missed something, and I would be happy to know myself wrong. It attracts intellectuals. It attracts young people to whom any other form of Jewish worship would be impossible—and I quote this from many, many instances of people who told me just so. Its study circles are taken very seriously, and the study material is on a very high level, attendance excellent, and enthusiasm high. It has produced adherents who have achieved great pride of identification with Jewish values and with the culture of Judaism. To it the focal rôle of Israel is explicit—the very heart of Judaism. I cannot myself go further than to record, as honestly as I know, what has been the revitalising value of Reconstructionism within Conservatism and how salutary the results have been. For those who can accept Reconstructionism, it is a panacea. For me it is emotionally arid. It makes short work of the uniqueness of Judaism, of the Jewish people and its survival, for it does not seek to inquire into what is or should be or might be the consequences to us, or to our relationship with non-Jewish society, of our being the Chosen People: it simply removes this relationship from its tenets, except in a purely symbolic sense. It has, it is true, applied contemporary philosophy to its reappraisal of Judaism and removed many of the anachronisms and atavisms which perhaps no longer apply. But in removing the *asher bachar banu* it has produced an emasculated, impersonal kind of ethical religion which I find emotionally unsatisfying and even sterile.

Hebrew in Services

Of the Conservative movement as a whole the greatest single achievement is the Jewish Theological Seminary, which is producing dedicated young rabbis with a genuine sense of the realities of today and of the eternal truths of Judaism and its universality. Beyond that, Conservatism, for me, is blatantly a compromise. It has taken cognisance of certain apparent truisms in contemporary Jewish life in America and built a way of life round them. But Conservatism is that trend most closely bound to the focal rôle of Israel in Jewish life in the Diaspora. It does seek to perpetuate Jewish life in America, but it holds tight to Israel's playing a focal rôle. It retains much of the warmth of traditional Judaism, and I found its services much more specific than those of most Reform temples. Hebrew plays a much more important rôle in Con-

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